

# Basketball

Basketball is a fast-paced ball sport, invented in Massachusetts, USA, in 1891 as an indoor game to keep students fit during the winter. It was originally played by shooting the ball into fruit-pickers' baskets, which is how the sport got its name.

## EQUIPMENT

One of the attractions of basketball is that you need very little equipment to play – just a ball and two baskets. Players do not even need special clothing, just suitable shoes for running on court.



**BALL**  
A modern ball is made of rubber or a synthetic composite covered in leather. It is 75–78 cm (30–32 in) in circumference and weighs 600–650 g (21–23 oz).



**BASKET AND BACKBOARD**  
The basket is a 45 cm (18 in) hoop with netting hanging from it, mounted on a vertical backboard.

## KEEPING SCORE

Spectators keep track of the score on a scoreboard. A basket made inside the three-point line scores two points. Baskets made from beyond the three-point arc score three points. When shooting a free throw, each basket made scores one point.



Time and score — Big screen  
Team and player stats — Space for advertising

## THE GAME

Two teams of five players each try to score points by shooting a ball through a hoop, which is 3.05 m (10 ft) above the ground. The winning team is the one that has scored most points by the end of the game.



LASTS  
48 MINUTES



4 QUARTERS OF  
12 MINUTES (NBA)



HAS 2 TEAMS OF  
5 PLAYERS

## LAWS OF THE COURT

The NBA (National Basketball Association) governs the professional game in the USA. The NBA sets out only 12 basic rules, although each rule is divided into many clauses and subsections. Differing governing bodies worldwide have slightly different rules.

### PERSONAL AND TECHNICAL FOULS

If a team commits a foul, the opposing team is given possession of the ball. If a team is fouled while shooting, they are awarded one or more shots at the basket. Fouls can be either personal – for example for pushing, blocking, or holding an opponent – or technical – for offences such as deliberate time-wasting or arguing with the referee. In the NBA, once a player has recorded six fouls, they may take no further part in the game.

### VIOLATIONS

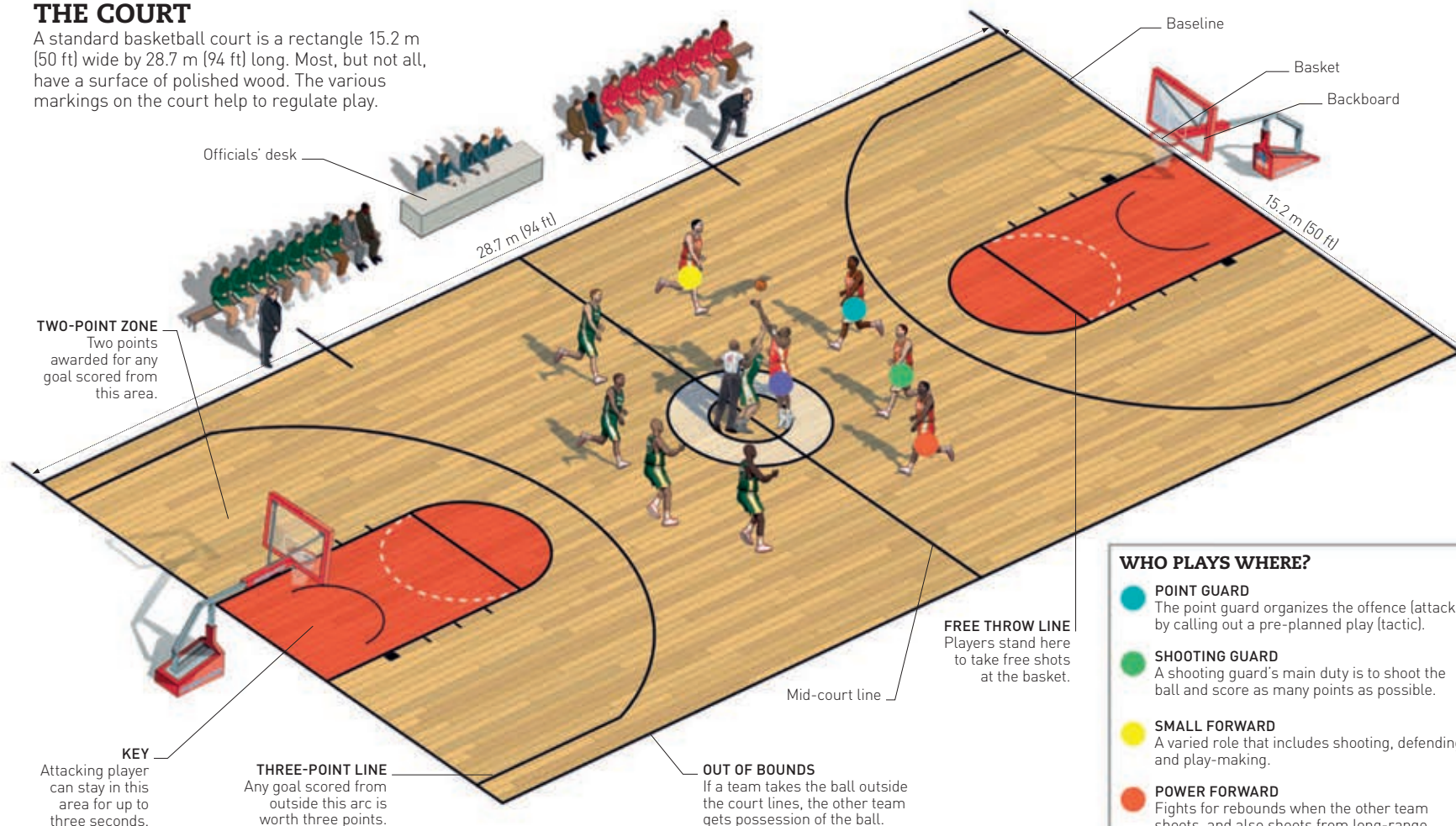
When a player breaks the rules, they commit a foul. For instance, players must dribble (bounce the ball in front of them) as they run. If they do not, they commit a foul known as "travelling".

### TIME LIMITS

Basketball is designed to be a fast-moving, attacking sport. In the NBA, once in possession of the ball, a team must attempt a shot within 24 seconds; if it does not, possession passes to the other team.

## THE COURT

A standard basketball court is a rectangle 15.2 m (50 ft) wide by 28.7 m (94 ft) long. Most, but not all, have a surface of polished wood. The various markings on the court help to regulate play.



### WHO PLAYS WHERE?

- **POINT GUARD**  
The point guard organizes the offence (attack) by calling out a pre-planned play (tactic).
- **SHOOTING GUARD**  
A shooting guard's main duty is to shoot the ball and score as many points as possible.
- **SMALL FORWARD**  
A varied role that includes shooting, defending, and play-making.
- **POWER FORWARD**  
Fights for rebounds when the other team shoots, and also shoots from long-range.
- **CENTRE**  
The centre is usually the tallest player and is the team's main shot-blocker.